THE PROJECT SUICIDE

(ORGANIZATIONAL PROFILE)

Discovering Hope: An Independent Suicide Awareness, Research, and Prevention Non-Profit Organization. We Envision a Society Where People Challenge Their Despair Instead of Quitting Their Lives.

Meet The Team

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The Project Suicide

The Project Suicide (TPS) is an independent, volunteer-run non-profit organization working in partnership with United Nations Association of Pakistan, dedicated to suicide awareness, research, and prevention in Pakistan. Founded on June 25, 2022, TPS aligns with SDG 3.4.2 and focuses on addressing the critical challenges of mental health and suicide prevention. Over the past two years, TPS has fostered a culture of seeking help by empowering youth through psychoeducation, project management, leadership development, and SDG awareness, resulting in saving 19 lives. Our strategic collaborations with esteemed organizations, including Catalyst Now, World Federation of United Nations Associations WFUNA, SpareBank I SMN Norway, and United Nations Association of Norway, have further fortified our commitment.

Our Vision

A society where people challenge their despair instead of quitting their lives.

Our Mission

To prevent mental health problems and suicide by conducting research, inspiring hope, empowering youth, and spreading awareness using a socially integrated approach.

Our Values

- Empathy
- Ethics
- Social Justice
- Innovation
- Dignity
- Service

Services & Values

Psychoeducation

Free of cost psychoeducation, psychological first aid training for students to play a role in mental health and suicide prevention.

Research (In Process)

Building knowledge economy by conducting epidemiological research in suicidology, adventure psychology and mental health.

Professional Help

Referral to professional Psychologists, suitable, accessible, and affordable.

Resources

Provision of research proved resources to be used for suicide prevention. Such as Safety Plans, Tools, and templates.

Awareness

Spreading awareness about suicide and mental health to enhance help seeking behavior and break the stigma.

Sustainability

Spreading awareness and educating youth about mental health sustainability and UN's SDGs to build capacity for the future.

Project Management and Leadership

As an emerging organization, currently we have added the value of delivering training on project management and leadership, specifically in mental health advocacy.

OUR

SERVICES & VALUES

Organizational Culture

At The Project Suicide, we embrace and prioritize a "Creative Organizational Culture," valuing creativity, curiosity, and innovative problem-solving in our approach to addressing mental health challenges. This commitment is evident in our initiatives, such as the implementation of novel solutions like **"The Time Bank /Qalb"** concept in Phase II and the innovative recruitment process and activities planned for **The Ambassadorship Program.** We believe that fostering a culture of creativity is essential for effectively delivering value to our target population and driving positive change in mental health and suicide prevention.

1 OUR LONG STORY SHORT…

Two and a half years ago, a friend of ours in a mask of humor said, *"how wonderful it would be if he just ended his life!"*, and in an acclamation to his merry manner, we replied: *"how wonderful indeed!"*

We started this project… Because… *a person died.* How, as friends, we could not see beneath the cheerful and happy demeanor of his, the profound gush of tears, despair, and helplessness he had nursed in his life. How, as the profession of a psychologist, apparently 'proficient in the mark of behavior detection', could not equip us with the right tools to penetrate the artificial and meek smiles of someone we saw every day. How our psychology degree had failed us miserably; and how we had failed humanity. From our experience, a shocking and concerning question faced us: How do we expect normal human beings to do better, if the so-called experts (psychologists) are failing us? This nudged us towards a turbulent action.

Evidently, observing the deeply imbedded taboo and stigma around suicide in Pakistan, we, conceived of an idea of helping the people of our country, and coined it as 'The Project Suicide'. That by conducting extensive research, people may be given the right tools to prevent suicide, play a role in its prevention and challenge their despair. Since then, we have been paying our long overdue debt of breaking the bonds of stigma, raising awareness in our culture, and prompting people towards psychological help and counselling. So far, our team's work has

resulted in saving **19 Lives.** And now, we are at least able to empower people to detect the humor-colored despair of their friends and loved ones and play a role to save them. But the professional journey continues a little bit differently…

2 THE LANDSCAPE OF MENTAL HEALTH IN PAKISTAN.

To understand the alarming and distressing landscape of mental health and suicide in Pakistan, especially the archaic bonds of stigma that were felt on a personal level, with friends and family and the local people around us we started our professional journey from archival research about mental health and suicide in Pakistan. And we found that with the recent paradigm change of the global world, social media's astounding prevalence into every facet of life, and the reconfiguration of the old traditional world into the global and artificial village that has become the 21st century, the landscape of society has become prevalent with novel and bizarre problems, the precarious mental health of people.

In Pakistan, an estimated 50 million people, equivalent to one in four of the population, are anticipated to grapple with mental health issues. Widespread stigma and inadequate awareness, lack of help-seeking behavior and research is worsening the problem. And because of the expensive and inaccessible mental health services, about 90% of those requiring treatment are unable to access necessary support. The situation has exacerbated, particularly after the COVID-19 pandemic and recent devastating floods.

According to the recent reports of WHO, the mortality rate of suicide in Pakistan is 8.9/100,000, around 57 deaths per day. However, further reports from WHO has revealed that Pakistan does not report suicide or when it does, it remains marginally underhand (World Health Organization, 2019 & 2022). Further scientific enquiries have revealed a powerful fear of stigma around suicide, due to the culture and religious norms endemic in the

country. The family of the person dying by it are ostracized by the rest of the society (Nasir et al. (2011); the incessant fear that their funeral will not be allowed by the local religious clerics to take place (Mahmood & Haq, 2014); the doctors here in hospitals brushing suicides and attempts daily under the carpet; while the police used to arrest people who attempted suicide under the law that it was criminal to kill yourself (Akhtar et al., 2016). The consequences of these obstacles in mental health treatment and suicide prevention, in Pakistan, each day reportedly 57 people die by suicide and more than 1200 people attempt it.

And this is not only about Pakistan, according to the comprehensive surveys of WHO around 1 million people die by suicide in a year around the globe. However, these reports are marginally modest, when the actual numbers of unreported suicides are approximated, the severity of these problems becomes nothing short of horrifying. Every 36 or 40 seconds, a person dies around the world; every 4 seconds, there is a suicide attempt. While for the first time, in the vast history of human civilization, more people are dying with their own hands than by someone else's through homicide, war or even cancer.

> ***"By the end of this sentence… 4 people would have attempted suicide."***

3 Professional Journey of The Project Suicide

After a few months archival research and planning, The Project Suicide's professional journey was started on 25th June 2022 with an endeavor of reducing, if not altogether extirpating the obstacles that were in the way of mental health and suicide prevention.

PHASE 1-EXPLORING ADVENTURE PSYCHOLOGY:

Starting on a local level and from whatever the available resources were at that time, we initiated our PHASE I with the primary objective of raising awareness among the general population, inspiring hope, and exploring Adventure Psychology and its implications in suicide and mental health prevention. To achieve our objectives, despite the lack of resources, a cycling adventure was planned to ride across different cities of North Pakistan and Explore Adventure Psychology in the North and spread awareness among the public, educational institutions. A rudimentary research data was collected from around the cities of Pakistan such as Skardu and Islamabad, to assess the nature and severity of the problem. Also, to understand Adventure Psychology and its implications in mental health and suicide prevention, extreme adventures from about four countries were interviewed.

The end of September 2022 marked the closing of cycling adventure. We started further consultation with the experts in the fields of mental health and Suicidology, a blueprint was developed for further action, taking the awareness around suicide as the main theme of the Project. ***(Refer to attached Phase-I report for further details).***

PHASE 2-BREAKING BARRIERS, RAISING AWARENESS FT. WFUNA X TPS:

This initiated PHASE II, with the main objective of scaling the project, creating a safe environment for dialogue about suicide and mental health, reducing mental health stigma on a bigger scale, hiring volunteers, and scaling the team from 4 Individuals to More than 40 Members (10x) and develop an organizational structure. And finally, to work on a national scale and catch the attention of national and international bodies to take action for mental health and suicide prevention or at least support us in our journey of suicide prevention.

The execution of awareness sessions, team building, partnerships started in November 2022 and after a month and one awareness session at one of the well know universities in Pakistan, in December 2022, we got the opportunity to apply for a Youth Action Program known as ***"Under the Starry Sky Program"*** by The World Federation of United Nations Associations (WFUNA), SpareBank 1 SMN Norway and UNA Norway. After the hard work of about 3 months and the innovative approach of the work in tackling mental health problems especially contributing to some principal Sustainable Developmental Goals (SDGs) such as SDG3, SDG4, SDG10 SDG17 and several others, in March 2023, we earned a coveted spot in the "Under the Starry Sky" program among 15 international projects selected from 3000 worldwide.

Under the guidance of these esteemed organizations, Phase II unfolded with meticulous project management training from the ***Project Management Institute (PMI),*** and we started execution with the bigger impact in mind and with a bigger team of enthusiasts. After the six months of rigorous planning, challenges, and a lack of resources, again we have made an amazing impact in mental health and suicide prevention in Pakistan. Specifically, psycho-educated more than **1600+ university students** and **saved 8 lives directly**. ***(Refer to the attached Phase-II report for further details).***

September 2023 marked the closing of our Phase II and culminated in a transformative 10-day ship expedition to Norway. During the Expedition, The Project Suicide was chosen from all the international projects, by The SpareBank1SMN for a Mini–Film Series which has been watched by about half a million people across the globe; our voice of hope reached to the globe. And we were published by a Norwegian Media Company MN24. For us, as a team, it was not only an expedition but an amazing opportunity to build a network and professional connections across the globe.

PHASE 3-TPS AMBASSADORSHIP PROGRAM CYCLE-I (2023-24):

Phase III of The Project Suicide began with the successful completion of Phase II, marking a significant milestone in our journey. Building on the global connections and collaborations formed during this period, we recognized the need to shift from solely conducting awareness and psychoeducation sessions to fostering systemic, sustainable, and impactful change in Pakistan's mental health landscape. As we reflected on Phase II, it became clear that reaching every corner of Pakistan was a profound challenge, given the country's diversity in languages and cultures. We realized that connecting with communities in Pakistan who are unfamiliar with our work—or finding it difficult to relate to us—needed a new strategy. Many regions in Pakistan have distinct languages and cultural norms, which can make it challenging for people to connect with mental health efforts led by those from outside their communities. To bridge this gap, we understood that local voices would be key to fostering genuine connections and trust.

With this in mind, Phase III launched at the end of December 2023, centered on an ambitious plan: the ***TPS Ambassadorship Program***. This innovative initiative aimed to expand our reach by building a strong network of student ambassadors across **34 universities** in **25 cities** in Pakistan. Recognizing that these ambassadors are local to their respective regions, speaking the language and understanding the culture, we saw an opportunity to train them as representatives who could connect more meaningfully with their communities. By empowering these ambassadors through targeted training, we equipped them to bring mental health awareness into areas that had previously been out of reach, effectively acting as relatable and trusted voices within their own communities.

The recruitment process for the Ambassadorship resulted in the selection of nine Team Leads and 56 Lead Ambassadors from 159 applicants. Guided by their Team Leads, these Lead ambassadors were tasked with forming their own teams of General Ambassadors within their universities. Ultimately, recruiting 350 ambassadors (Lead & General) for the program. These ambassadors received comprehensive training sessions remotely, focusing on psychoeducation, leadership, and project management, with notable contributions from the ***Project Management Institute (PMI) Switzerland*** in June, equipping them with essential tools to drive change.

Armed with this knowledge, the ambassadors initiated and implemented various small-scale local projects aimed at promoting mental health and suicide prevention within their communities. These efforts ranged from simple activities like distributing informational leaflets to more complex initiatives such as organizing discussion platforms and seminars that encouraged open dialogue around mental health, challenging stigma, and raising awareness among students and the broader public.

Over the course of just **Six months, 80 impactful activities** were successfully carried out across Pakistan, directly **psycho-educating 8,192** university students and **indirectly reaching 4,842** others. Most significantly, these

efforts led to the **referral of 114 individuals** to psychological professionals for therapy and the **saving of 2 lives**. ***(Refer to the attached Phase III report for further details.)***

These outcomes underscore not only the program's success in raising awareness but also its role in fostering empathy and resilience within communities. The strong foundation laid by these *Ambassadors of Hope* within their localities will continue to support mental health advocacy in educational institutions all across Pakistan.

PHASE 4-TPS AMBASSADORSHIP PROGRAM CYCLE-II (2024-25):

As we enter Phase IV of The Project Suicide, we are excited to launch Cycle II of the TPS Ambassadorship Program. This phase signifies a pivotal evolution, building on the insights and experiences gained from Cycle I while refining our strategies for greater impact. Our primary focus is to address the challenges faced in the inaugural cycle, enhance the program's structure, and broaden its scope to achieve a higher level of maturity and effectiveness. Significant advancements in this phase include forging strengthened partnerships with the **United Nations Associations of Pakistan (UNAP)** to provide UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) training for ambassadors and collaborate on future projects, as well as with the **Health Services Academy, under the Ministry of National Health Services Regulation and Coordination MoNHSRC**, to provide training on psychoeducation and also support in supervision and smooth execution of the program. New topics and domains like Decision Making & Critical Thinking have been introduced to strengthen ambassadors' capacity-building efforts, while top-performing ambassadors from Cycle-I have been promoted to leadership roles, offering them more challenging responsibilities. The number of participating universities has been doubled i.e., 65 and the tenure of the program has been extended to the whole academic year, enhancing our footprint all across Pakistan.

Preparations for Cycle II began immediately after the conclusion of Cycle I in August 2024. With UNAP as our first official partner of this phase, we laid a strong foundation within Pakistan. This was further reinforced by our collaboration with the Health Services Academy. These partnerships facilitated our expansion beyond Pakistan through the creation of the "**Mental Health Alliance Pakistan**" on the global SDGs platform, **Catalyst Now** (access this collaboration **Here**). This alliance granted us access to thousands of organizations worldwide, enabling collaborations with key entities such as **ODE Systems from Germany**, which provides training on Decision-Making **and Gilgal Dabihn from UK**, which delivers training on Project Management & Critical Thinking.

In the meantime, our internal team worked diligently over three months to build a robust structure for Cycle II. We celebrated the end of 2024 with successfully recruiting **4 Regional Managers** aka Operational Managers, each assigned to a specific region of Pakistan: Punjab, Islamabad, KPK, and Gilgit-Balochistan-Sindh. These managers oversee **12 Team Leads**, who in turn manage 5-6 universities each. Additionally, **650 Ambassadors**, both Lead and General, have been recruited from **65 Universities** across Pakistan. By mid-January 2025, we aim to

finalize team building within all 65 universities, led by the appointed Lead Ambassadors. The training phase is scheduled to commence in the last week of January. Over the course of the 2025 academic year, ambassadors will undergo extensive training in the aforementioned domains and execute mini-projects and activities based on their learnings.

With these improvements, our goal is clear: to raise awareness and promote mental health and build capacity in a more structured and impactful way. Our commitment extends to each and every corner of Pakistan from the far treacherous Mountains of the North to the gushing, majestic Sea in the South, leaving no stone unturned and no community untouched. Every effort we make is driven by a single, unifying vision:

> ***"A Society Where People Challenge Their Despair… Instead of Quitting Their Lives"***

Our Partnerships & Collaborations

UNAP

wfuna
World Federation of United Nations Associations

FN-SAMBANDET
UNITED NATIONS ASSOCIATION OF NORWAY

SpareBank 1 SMN

TEDxPIEAS
x = independently organized TED event

Catalyst Now

ODE

GILGAL DABIHN

Project Management Institute. Switzerland

PAKISTAN RED CRESCENT
بلالِ احمر پاکستان

HSA HEALTH & WELLNESS CENTRE
HEALTH SERVICES ACADEMY

&
60+ Pakistani Universities

OUR PARTNERSHIPS
&
COLLABORATIONS

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International Presence

Collaboration (Catalyst 2030)

https://catalyst2030.net/collaborations/mental-health-alliance-pakistan/

Documentary (Under The Starry Sky)

https://youtu.be/C0YJt-mqi2E?si=_UDuZV-HV-SeDzp3

SpareBank 1 SMN

https://www.sparebank1.no/nb/smn/om-oss/samfunnsutbytte/fn-ung-seilas.html

WFUNA

https://wfuna.org/sustainable-development/under-the-starry-skysailing-towards-sustainable-change-the-journey-of-100-young-visionaries/

CONTACT INFORMATION & ONLINE PRESENCE

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